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RESEARCH ARTICLE

Let's Not Talk About Archives: Open Research for Every Ethnomusicologist

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Abstract

This article makes a case for why ethnomusicologists—not just those with specialised interests in archives, information management, and intellectual property law—need a serious conversation about open research. Drawing on examples of ethical, regulatory, and infrastructure challenges encountered in the UK-based Access Folk project, I suggest the necessity of dialogue that crosses fault lines about data ownership and control. Articulating a coherent disciplinary-level stance about what open research means in ethnomusicology is an essential step toward a more ethical research praxis, positioning us to confront twenty-first-century technical and regulatory challenges.

Keywords: CARE principles; data management; FAIR principles; open research; risk management

The Access Folk project supports culture change within England's folk singing scene through research that prioritises accessibility, participation, and, ultimately, sustainability. This five-year project responds to a perceived decline in folk clubs since the height of England's second folk revival in the 1960s (Butler et al. 2023; Hield et al. 2026; cf. Hield and Mansfield 2019; MacKinnon [1993] 1994). In the twenty-first century, participation in folk singing skews to aging, male, heteronormative, white, middle-class, and well-educated demographics, though, as our research also shows, local realities are considerably more varied (Kay and Hield 2024; Kay 2025; Hield et al. 2026). Based at The University of Sheffield (TUoS), funded by a United Kingdom Research and Innovation (UKRI) Future Leaders Fellowship, and staffed by four ethnomusicologists—primary investigator Fay Hield and research associates Esbjörn Wettermark (2022–2027), Kirsty

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Kay (2022–2024), and myself (2023–2027)—as well as project manager Helen Grindley (2022–2027) and communications officer Rowan Piggott (2022–2027), the Access Folk team is guided by an advisory board of thirteen academics, arts organisations, and community members representing different interest groups from within/adjacent to England's folk scene (Access Folk 2026a).[1] Each stage of our project has prioritised consultation and co-production: research *with*—not on—the folk scene (cf. Vaughn and Jacquez 2020). Indeed, the participatory and activist nature of our research is an essential backdrop for thinking through the ethics and logistics making generated knowledge accessible beyond the life of the project. If the aim of our co-produced research is culture change that supports sustainable participation in singing, then stakeholders must have access to supporting datasets so that they can be self-determining in the application, deployment, and development new knowledge (UKRI 2025b).[2]

I came to the Access Folk project not as a scholar with deep expertise in English-language folk singing, but as an ethnomusicologist whose previous work included experience of participatory research design and practice research. Added to this mix were stints in sound and photo archives working on projects that developed historical collections for digital dissemination—projects that involved digitisation, metadata development, complex rights research, repatriation, and community engagement. Importantly, I came to this project as a precariously employed academic who has worked for five different institutions in three separate countries, on close to a dozen different contracts, on projects with distinct partners over the last decade. For me, this means persistent worries about my interlocutors' needs when I lose access to the systems that store their data. In sum, I came to the Access Folk project with the skills, the knowledge, and a personal stake in developing a participatory research project with the robust data management processes required for open research.

I joined the Access Folk team in October 2023 when the project, which began in February 2022, was already well underway. Building on foundational work about challenges to sustainable participation in the folk scene, my first task was

[1] The Access Folk project relies on contributions from the entire research team, a supportive advisory board, and our external co-researchers. This includes Small Project Grant holders based throughout England: Steph Meskell-Brocken (The Met, Bury), Rupert Philbrick (Music at the Heart of Teesdale, Durham), Anna Anise (Sunday Socials, Devon), Sophie Crawford (Harrison Singaround, London), Jennifer John (Folk to Folk, Liverpool), Miriam McDonald and Sarah Hinds (Heartwood CIC, Derby), Nev Meek and Kate Neale (Carols of the Roseland, Cornwall), Joanie Bones (Elephant in the Womb, London), Imi Fell (Songs from the Land, London), Jon Coley (Scribbling Town Folk Club, Manchester), Nigel Carden (Saltburn Folk Festival, North Yorkshire), Roary Skaista (Oxford), and Rosie Hodgson (Soundpost, Sheffield). Special thanks to Dr. Jenni Adams, Ric Campbell, and Kate O'Neill for their ongoing specialised support for Access Folk's open research goals. Comments and advice offered through open peer review by Dr. Muriel Swijghuisen Reigersberg and by an anonymous peer reviewer are sincerely appreciated.

[2] The Access Folk project did not begin with explicit open research goals. For details of how we approached making the project retrospectively open, see "Winners and runners-up of the Open Research Prize 2025" (Open Research n.d.). Data supporting this publication can be freely downloaded from the University of Sheffield research data repository at https://doi.org/10.15131/shef.data.c.7126222, under the terms of the open license specified in collection metadata.

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planning a new project phase that supported stakeholders to pilot their own locally relevant access interventions. Encouragement from our funder (UKRI 2025a) and changing priorities within our institutional research environment combined with the participatory nature of our project to suggest an additional goal: making our research design as open as possible by integrating the "FAIR Principles of Data Governance" into our planning (TUoS 2026a). Given that the participatory nature of the Access Folk project meant that we perceived an ethical imperative to support knowledge sharing among our stakeholders, following open research design principles seemed like a logical route to achieving this end. Realising these goals, however, has proven more complicated than we ever imagined. As our project stretches towards its finish line in January 2027, I'm conscious of the many setbacks that have hampered our efforts to deliver a truly open participatory research project that is focused on creative practices. Some of the stumbling blocks are the inevitable glitches, missteps, and unconsidered realities of ethnographic fieldwork. But often our challenges have been procedural, institutional, systemic, and, I will argue, disciplinary.

Ethnomusicological texts addressing major theoretical, methodological, and ethical issues in the first decades of the twenty-first century remain silent on the implications of external pushes for open research (e.g., Post 2017; Diamond and Castelo-Branco 2021; Stock and Diamond 2022).[3] Given the wide-ranging nature of challenges, it is perhaps not surprising that most discussions of open music research come from the perspective of quantitative computational and empirical musicology (e.g., Moss and Neuwirth 2021), with entangled issues also being raised in literatures on sound archiving (e.g., Seeger 1986, 1996; Landau and Fargion 2012; Cooper 2013; Western 2019), and information (e.g., Swijghuisen Reigersberg 2015, 2019) and rights management (e.g., Jaarsma 2002; Bachner 2005; Weintraub and Yung 2009; Carugno 2018; Born and Eisenberg 2025). While textbooks instruct on the importance of good record-keeping during fieldwork and the importance of generating quality documentation (e.g., Gilman and Fenn 2019), many ethnomusicologists still lack the necessary knowledge of data governance to enable data sharing outside of their direct control (Hemmasi and Brown 2025).

In this article, I make a case for why ethnomusicologists—and not just those with specialised interests in (sound) archives, information management, and intellectual property law—need a serious conversation about the relevance of open research to our discipline. I will do this by first describing what I mean by open research, defining data, and summarising the data governance principles that support openness. I will then offer up the Access Folk project as a case study

[3] While these anthologies might not explicitly address open research, they all raise related issues. Post's introduction flags the tendency to lock data away in personal archives (2017:32–33), as well as tensions between intellectual property rights and cultural rights (2017:25). Subsequent chapters by Diamond et al. (2017) on performing protocol, Stobart (2017) on the colonial nature of global intellectual property regimes, Wong (2017) on the cultural rights of minorised musicians, Vallier (2017) on the entangled disciplinary history of ethnomusicology and sound archiving, and Lobley (2017) on the future-oriented relationship of sound archives and communities raise key ethical, cultural, and regulatory issues.

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of the ethical, regulatory, and infrastructure challenges that impede data sharing. Finally, I will conclude with suggestions for how we might work at a disciplinary level to achieve greater levels of openness.

Notably, this is not an article about archives or a case study of a bespoke archiving solution that works around contextual complexities. Rather, it is an attempt to highlight how open research design challenges pertain to anyone who documents music, movement, and creative practices. My position will, inevitably, be incomplete, not least because my experience is limited to Canadian, Irish, and UK contexts, and my case study is based firmly in England. But that is part of my point: collectively, ethnomusicologists have incredible knowledge of local regulations and wide-ranging cultural protocols. We recognise that there are disparate understandings of ownership and access across the world, and value the decolonisation of knowledge production. We also understand sonic, visual, and kinaesthetic expressions as knowledge with intrinsic value for the people who produce it. Bringing this disciplinary mindset to questions about data governance, the ethics of sharing, and the functionality of supporting infrastructure is essential for realising more equitable relationships with the people who enable our research. Starting a dialogue that crosses fault lines about ownership and access to knowledge, the purpose of preservation, and, more broadly, about what open research means in ethnomusicology is an essential step towards a more ethical research praxis that positions us to confront new regulatory, technical, and data governance challenges head on.

The case for open research

At the broadest level, open research[4] prioritises making the data and processes upon which research outputs are constructed transparent, public, and accessible. Originating in the sciences—disciplines that typically prioritise experimental research design, large sample sizes, strict anonymisation procedures, and alphanumeric datasets—open research increasingly dominates the priorities of research institutions, funding bodies, and professional associations in a variety of national and disciplinary contexts (e.g., ERC n.d.; United Nations n.d.; Zhang et al. 2023; Chawla 2024; UKRI 2025a). The reasons for this push vary, but typically include reproducibility, developing extant datasets, transparent use of public funding, and equalising access to knowledge (Borgman 2012; Kraus and Eberhard 2022; Hemmasi and Brown 2025).

Some of these rationales may seem irrelevant to ethnomusicologists, who are often more concerned with maintaining relationships than thinking about the nature of the data produced. Our work, after all, is frequently inductive and based on long-term engagements with participants who help shape research questions

[4] "Open research" and "open science" are synonymous. I've preferred "open research" throughout as "'science' in anglophone jurisdictions is a term that tends not to include [arts, humanities, and social sciences] disciplines, although this is not the case in other languages where the term is inclusive of a broader range of academic fields" (Adams et al. 2026).

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and analyse results. What we see as data often extend beyond information generated by a clearly defined research question that launches a controlled set of experiments or observations in a particular location for a finite period. Our prioritisation of deep contextual and relational knowledge, too, may foster scepticism about open research or data sharing more generally. Jerolmack et al., for example, outline the contested relationship between open research and ethnographic data, emphasising the questionable relevance of "positivistic standards of verification … to the interpretive enterprise of ethnography," the potential for "fetishization of 'factual details'" to lend a false sense of objectivity to reflexive engagements with complex systems, and the risk that data transparency will further marginalise vulnerable and historically minoritised populations (2024:1).

And yet, speaking specifically to ethnographic datasets, anthropologists Wolfgang Kraus and Igor Eberhard suggest justifications for pursuing open research that are thoroughly rooted in the relational and contextual nature of our research. They point out that the complexity and volume of data generated through ethnographic research is rarely "fully exploited" in the original analysis —a circumstance that fails to do justice to the labour of producing the data in the first place. And second, they reason, ethnographic data are "historical by nature" such that the passage of time may make the data "interesting and relevant in unforeseeable ways, not only for researchers and their scientific communities, but also for those being researched" (Kraus and Eberhard 2022:192).

Awareness of the unique circumstances of each site of ethnomusicological research—of the complexities of negotiating international and local regulatory systems (Jensenius 2021; Münnich 2021; Born and Eisenberg 2025), of diverse cultural norms and protocols (Weintraub and Yung 2009; Post 2017; Reed 2019), and the ethical and economic consequences of sharing research data (Zemp 1996; Jaarsma 2002; Pruett 2011)—has fostered a head-in-the-sand approach to data management and stalled disciplinary level conversations about how to approach open research. Speaking to archival practice, ethnomusicologist Anthony Seeger long ago chastised our discipline, stating "Ethnomusicologists have not only failed to consider legal issues in an intellectual way, many have also failed to assist the people they record to protect their own rights to their music, dance, and performing arts" (1996:88). Little has changed in terms of the core arguments for better data governance in the forty years since he articulated his position (Seeger 1986), though new possibilities and threats have emerged alongside regulatory and technological developments (Seeger 2023).

The net result of ongoing failures to address not just how and why we might share our data, but the very nature of that data, means that a disproportionate amount of the knowledge generated through our work remains locked away in personal archives—or destroyed at the ends of projects, careers, and lives (cf. Luyk 2015; Post 2017:32). Dwelling in the unique characteristics of each case means that there is no need to develop a core set of tools and workflows. In effect, we are always starting from the beginning and building bespoke solutions (e.g., Giri 2025). This approach is, quite simply, hard. And time-consuming. And while best-case scenarios may result in some truly remarkable solutions for both communities and researchers, often it means that data—the knowledge

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generated with and by our interlocutors—rapidly becomes inaccessible in the face of resource deficits, technology changes, and regulatory challenges.

Open research beyond reproducibility

UNESCO defines open research as "an inclusive construct," based on "key pillars [of]: open scientific knowledge, open science infrastructures, science communication, open engagement of societal actors and open dialogue with other knowledge systems" (UNESCO 2021:II.6). But as Adams et al. stress, open research "as it is operationalised in practice, especially in Global North contexts, fails to align with UNESCO's diverse and inclusive vision" (2026:4). Scholarly systems of incentives, institutional and funder requirements, and official metrics tend to overemphasise the first of these pillars. The open research that counts prioritises open access publishing (i.e., making scholarly research outputs like articles and monographs freely available) and open science infrastructure (i.e., repositories for sharing datasets) in pursuit of the reproducibility goals that are most relevant in medical-scientific research practices (2026:4). This version of open research narrowly focuses on dissemination to other researchers. Noting the host of practices common in the social sciences and humanities that emphasise research communication, engagement with societal actors, and dialogue across knowledge systems, Adams et al. (2026) propose a more flexible inventory of open research practices that move beyond scholarly publishing and data sharing.[5] This is still nascent work, but holds promise for validating and systematising the types of knowledge sharing that are most common in ethnomusicology.

Though reproducibility is rarely a priority, ethnomusicology has a higher rate of open access publishing than most other music disciplines (Franke 2021). Indeed, ethnomusicologists have debated and innovated open access formats, critically engaging the form and purpose of knowledge dissemination, as well as notions of authorship (Mueller et al. 2014; Swijghuisen Reigersberg 2019). We have also tended to take a leadership role in publishing open access translations of ethnomusicological texts.[6] This investment of resources reflects a disciplinary-level prioritisation of access to knowledge within and beyond the academy, as well as a valuing of dialogue across cultural and linguistic barriers (Franke 2021).[7] Open access publications, however, are typically interpretive: reliant on the training, analytical priorities, and cultural perspectives of researchers. But as Seeger long ago pointed out, "The people from whose music

[5] These practices of openness include co-production, collaborative translation, participatory research, documenting creative methods, sharing creative outputs, documenting failures, checking data with interlocutors, and foregrounding positionality.

[6] E.g., The Society for Ethnomusicology publishes *Ethnomusicology Translations* with the goal of increasing "access to the global scope of music scholarship and advance ethnomusicology as an international field of research and communication" (Ethnomusicology Translations 2026).

[7] E.g., *Traditions of Music and Dance* (ICTMD), *Ethnomusicology Forum* (BFE), and *Ethnomusicology* (SEM) all support varied levels of open access, with associated costs assumed by authors, their institutions, and professional societies.

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we have developed our general theories about music-making are not always enthusiastic about the theories we have produced"—it is the materials upon which those theories are based that hold fascination (1986:266). While we might rightly take pride in investments by researchers, professional societies, granting agencies, and research institutions in open access publishing, the results of such efforts still mediate access to our interlocutors' knowledge through substantive analytical, creative, and/or editorial processes (Franke 2021). Moreover, Franke (2021) explains that the high costs associated with open access publishing replicate historical academic inequalities as authors and institutions from the Global South are effectively excluded. Such investments, in other words, do not necessarily engage the priorities of societal actors (cf. UNESCO 2021) or address systemic global inequalities.

Publishing—open access, scholarly, or otherwise—is a mechanism of openness, offering potential for methodological innovation and co-production, while also providing a route to research data. Ethnomusicologists have long advocated the use of digital and multimedia technologies to enable access to audiovisual examples as supplements to published textual analysis (Harley et al. 2010:508; Mueller et al. 2014). Especially since the early 2000s, tucking a CD into the cover of a monograph or using passwords to access streaming playlists on publisher websites has become normative.[8] Less formal options, such as YouTube links or content hosted on personal websites, are now commonplace options for sharing audiovisual examples—with varied risks and often frustrating results, as anyone who has followed a broken link in a journal article knows (Messarra et al. 2026)! Digital and online technologies offer gateways to data for non-academic stakeholders, with ethnomusicologists and archivists exploiting the potential of the digital humanities for widely accessible, online, and curated collections (e.g., Landau and Fargion 2012; Diamond and Brodie 2013; Giri 2025). At their best, these websites offer public access to stably preserved collections with long-term maintenance plans. Unfortunately, such projects too often end without resourcing for updates, suffer link rot, intellectual property and cultural rights prove too complex or costly to maintain, and access disappears (Seeger 2023; Western 2019). The results of such efforts offer insight into sustainability and infrastructure challenges, but their ad hoc nature does not equate to open research (Harley et al. 2010; Tal-Socher and Ziderman 2020).

Data governance

A recent special issue of *MUSICultures* on "Archives, Access, and Ethnomusicology" (Risk and Tulk 2025) offers an important exception to the silence on open research in our field. A case study by Hemmasi and Brown details the structural,

[8] E.g., Diamond et al. (2017) provide an extended discussion of negotiating relevant cultural protocols and intellectual property rights to enable inclusion of an accompanying CD with her *Native American Music in Eastern North America* (2008). The types of documentation required, systems of permission, and challenge of doing this work retrospectively are relevant to any discussion of open research.

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methodological, and rights-based challenges to sharing music research data. They highlight the labour involved in such undertakings and advocate that ethnomusicologists treat their data management plans with "as much care and consideration as every other facet of research design" (2025:90). Fundamentally, open research is about data governance—about methods that are built into research projects from their inception that support clear understanding of what (and how) data are produced, as well as how that data should be responsibly accessed in the future. Open research does not mean putting raw data online or blindly sharing sensitive, proprietary, or otherwise restricted knowledge. It does mean actively documenting data management procedures to enable responsible decision-making about what constitutes the dataset, along with how and with whom data might be shared—ideally without relying exclusively on the gatekeeping of individual researchers.

Many ethnomusicologists first encounter the challenges of sharing data when projects—or careers—come to a close (e.g., Kraus and Eberhard 2022; Russell 2024). They discover the "tricky and time consuming" nature of "adding metadata and other documentation 'after the fact'" (Hemmasi and Brown 2025:84; cf. Diamond et al. 2017; Seeger 1986). Names, dates, locations, and details of what the data captures may be lost to memory, along with the potential for securing necessary agreements for data to be legally and ethically shared. Hemmasi and Brown (2025) report on a long-term ethnographic study of punk and metal music venues in the Kensington Market area in Toronto, Canada, focusing on how they implemented data governance procedures. The team-based and longitudinal approach meant that data processing was not always handled by a single person and that the researchers who collected the data sometimes moved on before data were fully processed. As their case study highlights, failure to follow a shared data management plan created scenarios where data were not just unshareable, but where the project team could not access collected data in fulfilment of their research goals.

The potential for effective collaborative working depends on research data being findable, accessible, interoperable, and re/usable (FAIR)—qualities defined in the dominant paradigm for designing open research (GoFair n.d.; Wilkinson et al. 2016):

- **Findable:** Data should be easy for humans and computers to find and interpret. Data are richly described with relevant metadata (i.e., description of what the data is), meta/data are assigned persistent identifiers, and meta/data are registered or indexed in a searchable resource.
- **Accessible:** Once found, people need to understand how to access data. Even when data itself cannot be made openly available, metadata should detail storage location, methods of authentication, and terms for authorising access.
- **Interoperable:** Data need to be in formats that enable integration with other data for the purposes of analysis, storage, and processing. Typically, this means preferring open file formats and formulating metadata according to established standards.

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- **Reusable:** Metadata clearly describe the provenance and ownership of data, supporting compliance with privacy and other data protection requirements and terms of reuse (i.e., licensing).

One of the goals of the Norway-based MusicLab project is methodological innovation in empirical music research, including FAIR research design for documenting performance events (Jensenius 2021). While concluding that robust data management goes a long way towards answering calls for greater openness, Jensenius (2021) notes that music scholarship—or, I would argue, any scholarship that centres ethnographic observation, creative and/or expressive practices, and co-produced knowledge—involves specific challenges to the FAIR Principles. These are: (1) the multimedia and multimodal nature of data; (2) privacy and data protection; and (3) intellectual property and cultural rights. To these challenges, I'm inclined to add a fourth related to the participatory and co-produced nature of much ethnomusicological data: visibility and access beyond the "official" structures of research institutions. A notable limitation of the FAIR Principles is that they prioritise description of data over consideration of the people producing the knowledge or the uses to which it will be put (GIDA NA). The co-produced and relational nature of ethnomusicological data creates an ethical prerogative to make data findable and accessible to stakeholders who cannot depend on institutional affiliations to demonstrate their "legitimate interest" in the data.

Multimedia and multimodal data

One of the challenges of open research design in ethnomusicology is clarity over the definition of data. Archivist Sean Luyk points out that there is a "notable gap in the literature regarding humanities research data, and very little about ethnomusicology, or music at all for that matter" (2015:3). This is a problem for ethnomusicologists because our data takes so many forms, extending considerably beyond the audiovisual recordings that tend to be the focus of available literature. Our data include text-based formats that are common across the social sciences and humanities—like questionnaires, interview transcripts, and fieldnotes. But it also includes music notation and transcriptions that may require specialised knowledge, systems, and software to generate, preserve, and access. The ephemera of performances and participatory cultural activities are data, and include promotional materials, sacred or ceremonial items, documentation of protocol, or elements of material culture—like instruments and costumes. Our data include the methods and results of creative processes that exist in a variety of formats, each with distinct challenges for preservation and sharing—and which may be best suited to storage within a physical archive or museum. Our data also comprise sound and video recordings that document wide-ranging sound and movement practices situated in vastly varied contexts.

Recordings serve a variety of purposes, ranging from documentation of performance practices and repertoire to supporting ethnographic observation (or other methodological functions), aiding transmission processes, and surfacing relevant cultural protocols. The range of functions for field recordings is

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broad, with implications for the nature and re/use of recordings (e.g., quality, perspective, technology, and audience). Landau and Fargion (2012) prompt consideration of what is meant by recording "for our own research purposes" in their preface to a special issue of *Ethnomusicology Forum.* Included articles offer twenty-first-century case studies of how archival recordings offer meaningful tools for community engagement and collaboration, with ethnomusicologists filling roles as "culture brokers" in efforts to repatriate and/or proactively build local archives. The special issue challenges the ambivalence to archives that emerged as a response to our discipline's colonial history during the twentieth century by demonstrating the decolonising potential of sound collections.

The authors do not, however, clarify what ethnomusicological data are or differentiate uses for recording. As Landau and Fargion point out, "much of the deliberation and debate" related to the methods, technologies, and ethics of collecting and disseminating ethnomusicological data has tended to happen "for and within the audiovisual archiving world" even though "recordings, archives and ethnomusicology have been inextricably linked throughout their histories" (2012:128). They suggest that, despite being written by ethnomusicologists who are also archivists, "the existing literature on audiovisual archiving has not reached many ethnomusicologists" (2012:128). This siloing of discussion in specialist literature misses something important about the nature of ethnomusicological data: its multimodal nature. Commentary instead focuses on recording for documentation—recording that prioritises the creation of archival objects that are understandable as standalone artefacts—without explicit consideration of how sound recording functions as a research process (cf. Fargion 2009).

Roshanak Kheshti's (2015) theorisation of the "aural traces" of sound recordists, though directed at the production of world music recordings, is useful for thinking through this question of recording for documentation versus research, and what that means in terms of the production and preservation of data. Kheshti points out that recordings capture more than sound; decision-making based on the recordist's priorities also leaves marks, influencing focus, start and end points, mix, and so on (2015:32). Recordings made "for our own research purposes" include traces of research methods and goals. They might, for example, offer low-quality sources that support transcription, document a transmission process rather than sonic or visual practice, or support practitioner reflections on their praxis. Recordings "for research purposes" may document something quite distinct from music or dance, and meaning may be contingent on other types of documentation. Data, in other words, that are truly multimodal, methodological, and ill-suited for publication without substantive contextualisation or links to larger datasets. Focusing the debate about data, preservation, and dissemination within specialist discussions of sound archiving neglects this multimodal nature, leaving us ill-equipped to address challenges inherent in the unique nature of our research.

This lack of clarity has implications beyond our discipline: if we cannot clearly articulate what our data is, how can we expect the people who support us to understand? The multidisciplinary research ethics boards responsible for reviewing our methods and developing institutional policies, for example, may

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misunderstand the nature of data generated through ethnomusicological research, resulting in frustrations on all sides and overly risk-averse processes that do not necessarily serve the interests of stakeholders (Bishop 2009; cf. Wakaruk et al. 2025). Definitional clarity is also a problem for data management professionals, whose systems may be ill-equipped to deal with collections featuring widely varied forms and formats with specific regulatory challenges. Many libraries and archives divide responsibility for their collections by format, meaning that contextualising texts, transcripts, or notation may be separated from audiovisual recordings (e.g., Wittgren 2025). This challenge is compounded by a reality that not all libraries, archives, and repositories have the infrastructure, knowledge, or mandate to preserve and disseminate all data types. Writing on the proliferation of born-digital heritage objects—inherently multimodal objects that require "the existence of increasingly complex and flexible systems"—Goudarouli et al. point to the increased necessity of "high levels of technical skill from both curator and researcher" to manage "unique preservation and access challenges" (2026:4). In other words, effective management solutions for multimodal data require multidisciplinary collaborations.

Privacy and data protection

Much of the tension between open and ethnographic research relates to the privacy of our interlocutors. Ethnographic research depends on rich contextual details that are likely to identify research participants, even when direct identifiers are stripped from the data. Such details are essential to the meaning and significance of the data. Ethnomusicologists take a negotiated approach to identifying research participants, recognising that the co-produced nature of our research comes with ethical obligations to respect interlocutors' wishes about how they are identified. Some musicians and dancers want to be publicly recognised for their contributions, while others eschew acknowledgement or prefer anonymity (Hield et al. 2024). The nature of our research area, too, means that separating traditional knowledge from originator(s) poses risks to creators and communities: tracking data provenance is essential to ensuring appropriate access and usage (Zemp 1996; Guy 2002; Draisey-Collishaw 2025). In short, research that focuses on expressive practices often requires identification of practitioners because (1) documenting the practice requires accurate capture of physical likenesses and/or identifying sonic features, and (2) practitioners need to be named in the metadata to protect their intellectual property and/or cultural rights.

Research contexts come with distinct regulatory and structural challenges when it comes to identifying research participants. General Data Protection Regulation in the UK (like the European Union) defines legitimate terms for processing and storing personal data. Under UK GDPR (2016), personal data are "any information relating to an identified or identifiable natural person ('data subject')," including "a name, an identification number, location data, an online identifier or to one or more factors specific to the physical, physiological,

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genetic, mental, economic, cultural or social identity of that natural person" (ICO n.d.[9]). This definition covers any information that can identify a person, including images and recorded sounds. While UK GDPR (2016) defines processing personal data for research and archiving as legitimate interests, this regulatory context complicates access to infrastructure for preservation and data sharing, especially when it comes to data that include ethnographic description or creative outputs.[10] Digital data repositories that make collections freely available online, for example, will not accept data where individuals are identifiable without their explicit consent. This can be a difficult bar to meet, especially if documentation includes public, informal, and/or participatory performance events.

Archives and repositories that offer "controlled access"—that is, where access is limited to authorised individuals or groups who demonstrate legitimate interest—are better able to preserve and share datasets that include unconsented personal data and data with complex intellectual property and cultural rights, but the availability of suitable options is limited in England and internationally (e.g., Harley et al. 2010; Hofmann et al. 2021). A 10 July 2026 search of the Registry of Research Data Repositories (re3data.org n.d.) listed only twenty-four repositories specialising in "musicology" data worldwide, with this number increasing to twenty-nine if "social and cultural anthropology and ethnology" repositories were included. Repositories that have specific geographic and/or cultural remits are often better situated to evaluate what constitutes legitimate access and take risk-managed approaches that are in dialogue with the needs of researchers and the communities they service (e.g., PARADISEC 2026). Research and cultural traditions that fall outside of these specialist remits, however, remain underserviced.

The ethics of privacy are of global relevance and especially complex in the present moment. Widespread adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) is coupled with regulatory uncertainty, resulting in unforeseen risks to individuals and communities represented in research data (Oruc 2025; Brunschweiger 2026). Preserving and disseminating data in 2026 involves privacy considerations that simply were not relevant in 1986, when accessing data involved visiting a physical premises and negotiating usage with an archivist. Even in 2006, when digital and online technologies were changing how data were shared and introducing new threats, there was not the same potential for completely uncontrolled access and unauthorised dissemination by generative AI. And yet, these same technologies hold potential for safeguarding and servicing the needs of our interlocutors. Hemment et al. (2025) point to AI's potential for responsibly and ethically processing data. Technologies like smart contracts, for example, may support reliable provenance tracking and responsible reuse according to creator/community licensing terms, as well as enabling the

[9] The Information Commissioner's Office (ICO) is the UK's independent regulator for Data Protection and Freedom of Information (see also UK GDPR 2016).

[10] The Access Folk project's legal bases for processing personal data is "a task carried out in the public interest" (UK GDPR 2016:Article 6(1)(e)), and "for archiving purposes in the public interest, scientific research purposes or statistical purposes" (UK GDPR 2016:Article 9(2)(j)).

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confidentiality of data sources. Assessing the risks and accessing the potential of such technologies, however, requires good data governance to start.

Intellectual property and cultural rights

Ethnomusicologists have long been aware that recordings made in the field have the potential to attract the interest of individuals who lack commitment to the rights of our interlocutors. Materials get taken and repurposed, used without reference to cultural meaning or protocols, and creators go unacknowledged and uncompensated for their knowledge and art. Scenarios for the exploitation of intellectual property and/or the violation of cultural rights are well-documented (e.g., Zemp 1996; Guy 2002; Pruett 2011), as are the incommensurate nature of cultural rights and existing intellectual property right regimes (e.g., Weintraub and Yung 2009; Post 2017; Reed 2019) and unequal impacts of regulation across traditions and geographies (e.g., Stobart 2017; Born and Eisenberg 2025). More positively, concurrent with the rise of easy-to-access digital technologies, archiving projects are demonstrating how ownership, control, and access to knowledge might be re/negotiated, either through repatriation of extant collections or through community-engaged digital preservation initiatives (e.g., Landau and Fargion 2012; Giri 2025; Risk and Tulk 2025). While the issues raised by these initiatives are relevant to open research, reporting tends to be on individual projects with bespoke "archive as output" solutions. Little attention is given to more systemic approaches to data governance and mobilisation, or how risks and rewards might play out in research that does not prioritise archiving as a named project output (cf. Seeger 2023).

Why does taking a more systemic approach to rights management matter? Even under the best of circumstances, rights research is challenging and slow.[11] Clearing an entire dataset retrospectively is almost impossible without metadata documenting provenance and terms of reuse (Diamond et al. 2017). Indeed, lack of relevant documentation is often a key factor that keeps ethnomusicological data locked away in private collections. That is because sharing data with intellectual property rights involves risks—risks to rights holders, risks to the people and platforms doing the sharing, and risks to (re)users. These legal, financial, and ethical risks are amplified in digital contexts where sharing is, to a degree, uncontrolled (and without the statutory and moral safeguards traditionally provided by brick-and-mortar archives).[12] Open data repositories, in consequence, tend to be risk intolerant: only data that exist in the public domain or that have clear agreements in place with all rights holders can be deposited (e.g., UK Data Service 2026a; cf. Hemmasi and Brown 2025; Korn et al. 2026).

[11] Simply tracing rights holders takes half a day per item in the case of "orphan works" (copyrighted works with unknown or untraceable rights holders), estimates Korn et al. (2026:403).

[12] My analysis focuses on intellectual property rights and associated economic risks as these are what most impact the capacity to share via existing institutional structures. Cultural rights typically do not receive the same level of legal protection, though a compelling ethical case for clearly documenting rights holders and terms of reuse exists (Hudson 2024).

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Risk aversion—and the desire to protect rights holders—might be reasonable, but digging into what this means in practice reveals the impracticalities. UK intellectual property law, for example, grants creators automatic and non-transferable moral rights over their creations. This includes the right of attribution: the right to be named as a creator. Original works also hold copyright(s) that give creators the exclusive right to control the use of their work. While moral rights do not expire, copyright typically lasts for at least fifty years after the death of the creator (Berne Convention 1886), though many countries—like the UK—have extended this to seventy years (UK Intellectual Property Act 2014). Given the multiplicity of rights holders involved in documentation of creative practices (e.g., rights holders for a single audio recording potentially include musicians, composers and lyricists, publishers, and the recordist), it is often impractical to identify (let alone gain consent from) everyone involved. Indeed, the increased duration of copyright over the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, when combined with the non-commercial nature of documentation and high rates of risk aversion, has resulted in what intellectual property rights scholar Naomi Korn terms "a black hole of 20th [and 21st] century content" suitable for digital preservation and dissemination (Korn et al. 2026).

While UK Intellectual Property Law includes a "fair dealing" exception that is relevant for research and preservation,[13] applying this exemption requires a degree of risk tolerance that is lacking in practice. Fair dealing lacks a statutory definition, meaning that the courts assess it on a case-by-case basis that accounts for whether usage affects the market for the original work, as well as whether the amount of the work taken is reasonable and appropriate (Wakaruk et al. 2025). Updates in 2014 broadened fair dealing exceptions, especially in the areas of parody, citation, and research, but invoking exceptions in relation to data preservation tends to depend on the availability of controlled access archives (Intellectual Property Office 2014). Small and specialist multimedia archives that more commonly handle these types of data may use a variety of risk management tools (like provenance research and takedown notices) to assess, make available data, and manage potential rights infringements (Korn 2021; Korn et al. 2026), but such services are unequally available and often underresourced.

Keeping data locked away might be a natural response to avoiding risks, but it also neglects the interests of the people with whom we do research and avoids surfacing the necessity of disciplinary-level debate about what constitutes ethical risk-managed approaches to sharing data with complex rights (Bishop 2009). While informed consent processes (written, aural, and/or continuous), contracts, and recording/image release forms might be norms in our discipline,

[13] "Fair dealing," defined in Sections 29 and 30 of the UK's Copyright, Designs and Patents Act (1988), is a much more limited concept than that of "fair use" as defined in US law. "Fair dealing" allows limited use for non-commercial research and private study; text and data mining for non-commercial research; criticism, review, and reporting current events; teaching; helping disabled people; time-shifting; and parody, caricature, and pastiche. Fair dealing is also found in Commonwealth nations, including Canada, Australia, New Zealand, Singapore, and South Africa, with local variations.

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workflows tend to be designed on a per-project basis and may prioritise mitigating institutional risk over long-term rights management with implications for data preservation and reuse beyond the project. More disciplinary knowledge is needed about the types of metadata tracking that need to be built into data collection or how use of culturally appropriate and internationally recognisable rights and licensing regimes—including Creative Commons, Traditional Knowledge Labels, Nwulite Obodo Open Data Licences (NOODL)—can become a foundation for relationship building with participants and partners (Local Contexts n.d.; Creative Commons 2026; Licensing African Datasets 2026).[14]

Co-produced knowledge and access

Despite the specific challenges that ethnomusicological research poses to the FAIR Principles, they are an effective starting point for planning research, encouraging attention to consistent data description, use of open storage formats, and consideration of how data might legally and ethically be processed into the future. FAIR also offers standardised language for interdisciplinary communication about research and data management requirements. A fundamental limitation of the Principles, however, is their narrow focus on the characteristics of the data. Indeed, with their origins in the sciences and prioritisation of a digital-first understanding of data, the FAIR Principles do not adequately account for the ethical obligations inherent in co-produced datasets.

Data produced in conjunction with research institutions typically flows through researchers and remains in restricted project archives in compliance with data protection, privacy, and intellectual property regulations. With forethought and planning, researchers can resist this enclosure through contracts and agreements that ensure partners retain control of their data. These efforts, however, are constrained by broader structural challenges (Vince-Myers 2025). Institutional data repositories serve the needs of researchers, with little consideration of other potential users; external partners are thus unable to directly deposit their data, necessitating dependence on researchers with institutional affiliations. Moreover, authentication processes that are in place to assess "legitimate interest" may restrict access to researchers with institutional affiliations. The authority to sustainably preserve, share, and benefit from data remains under the control of research institutions—a significant problem when the goal is more equitable access to knowledge (Ball et al. 2019).

The Global Indigenous Data Alliance (GIDA) prompts attention to how histories and power differentials implicate the nature of data sharing. They explain

[14] Creative Commons is an open licensing framework that enables rights holders to specify conditions of reuse (e.g., reuse is allowable if the creator is attributed or reuse is non-commercial, etc.). Traditional Knowledge labels, in contrast, are suitable for use in contexts where the concept of intellectual property is culturally inappropriate. The labels enable communication of collective cultural rights in a framework that is compatible with international data management standards. Developed beginning in 2022, NOODL addresses inequalities in resourcing that result in open African datasets being commercialised and sold back to source communities without regard for community ownership. This framework enables source communities to set conditions on reuse that support communal benefit.

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that "greater data sharing alone creates a tension for Indigenous Peoples who are also asserting greater control over the application and use of Indigenous data and Indigenous Knowledge for collective benefit" (GIDA n.d.). As an alternative to FAIR, they propose the CARE Principles (Collective benefit, Authority to control, Responsibility, and Ethics) as a people- and purpose-oriented approach to data governance that both supports open research and prioritises the interests of stakeholder communities. The CARE Principles have been systematised through initiatives like the Traditional Knowledge Labels (Local Contexts n.d.), offering evidence from a variety of global contexts about how open research practices can be compatible with (1) local interests and cultural rights and (2) the data management systems of research, heritage, and memory institutions (Hudson 2024). Notably, applying the CARE Principles depends on the availability of an authoritative body (e.g., band council, council of elders, or appointed community advisory board) that can speak for collective interests (cf. Schulder and Hanke 2022). Even in the absence of such a body, core ideas about how communities benefit, who has authority over the data, researcher responsibility, and ethical usage are critical for addressing the shortcomings of the FAIR Principles for ethnomusicological research and data—and for designing the systems that support access.

Access Folk and the challenge of openness

My first task on joining the Access Folk team was to realise a framework for action research initiatives that tested strategies for increasing access to participatory folk singing opportunities within England. Action research is an iterative methodology that is most frequently deployed in messy, real-world scenarios where change is sought but too many uncontrolled variables exist to disentangle. Instead, plans are made to work towards a desired goal. Those plans are acted upon, and then participants, organisers, and researchers reflect on whether the desired end was met. This kicks off another iterative cycle, with small changes that enable progress towards the desired outcome (Lewin 1946; Reason and Bradbury 2024). Positioned as responses to our earlier research (especially Bones et al. 2024; Butler et al. 2023), we made available thirteen £1000 Small Project Grants (SPGs) for individuals and/or organisations interested in running projects that offered novel approaches to widening participation. By inviting project proposals, we sought to recruit knowledgeable local experts with varied lived experiences to weigh in on what access means to them.[15] We envisaged each project as a case study for a particular context, with feedback about what worked, what showed potential, and ideas for next steps that could be iterated in an extension phase or passed on to other organisers to adapt and trial in their respective contexts. Sharing data about projects with our research partners and the wider folk singing scene, in other words, was essential. We did not, however, conceptualise SPG projects as including a bespoke archival or digital humanities output.

[15] See Access Folk (2026b) for the call for applicants and supporting materials.

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SPG holders ran their initiatives independently with the academic team providing support for planning, research, and networking. As the participatory folk singing scene typically relies on voluntary labour (Hield et al. 2024), we sought to minimise data collection activities for our partners. SPG holders attended a planning meeting and completed a series of four reflections (typically a conversation with a member of the academic team) about their projects' successes, failures, and next steps. This was the primary data associated with each project. We also requested that SPG holders share any naturally occurring data about their projects (e.g., organisational policy documents, promotional materials, handouts, etc.) and, if appropriate, allow a member of the academic team to attend and document an activity—only public-facing events where the presence of the academic team would not disrupt event flow or interpersonal dynamics were deemed appropriate. SPG holders sometimes requested that the academic team help design supporting data collection, facilitate focus groups with participants, or design feedback questionnaires. Some SPG partners also shared other forms of documentation, like photographs or recordings of meaningful moments that illustrated a key process or culminating moment in their project.[16] Datasets from each project typically were multimedia and multimodal; they included a mixture of written documents, meeting minutes, recorded interviews, and materials ranging from posters to participant feedback, lesson plans to songbooks, and photographs to song recordings.[17]

The challenge of sharing data between SPG holders and the wider folk scene was highlighted in May 2025 when the academic team hosted a networking event that brought together SPG holders, other Access Folk collaborators, and stakeholders from the wider folk scene to discuss equality, diversity, and inclusion in folk singing. In addition to sharing details of SPGs, participants discussed next steps, resource sharing, and mechanisms for mutual support. Participants expressed their desire to continue supporting each other and developing knowledge garnered through their projects, even after the Access Folk project concludes. However, connecting a geographically dispersed and largely voluntary network of organisers or sustainably hosting shared data remain unresolved challenges. Individual SPG holders may host details about

[16] Some SPG holders also published and disseminated their own outputs. Examples include a carol book with instructions on how to organise a traditional carol tour (Neale et al. 2024), a documentary film that explores how a group of women came to live in a multicultural urban centre through folk song (Crean 2025), and an album that re/writes women into folk repertoire (Bones 2025). SPG holder Jennifer John and her "Folk to Folk" project also featured in a BBC podcast (Elliot 2025). These published outputs offer windows into the scope of issues tackled through the SPG projects, but only represent projects with specific performative outcomes.

[17] Detailed description of the projects, methods, and ethics of this work—including consultations and decision-making about payments—is beyond the scope of this paper. In keeping with the principles of open research as defined by UNESCO (2021), our methodology and supporting research tools (including terms of the collaboration agreements with SPG holders) are available via ORDA (see Draisey-Collishaw et al. 2025a, 2025b). A series of blogs that report on individual projects is currently under preparation, as is a peer-reviewed article addressing the methodological underpinnings of the project and related ethical challenges.

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their projects on their websites or post updates on social media platforms, but these strategies for sharing often result in a siloing of information: data are not reliably findable, accessible, or reusable for a diverse national network of scene organisers. These platforms, too, are not stable. Shared links to Instagram posts detailing developments in SPG projects, for example, were often dead within a matter of months—sometimes before data could be fully processed by the academic team. As digital humanist Luca Messarra points out in a report for the Internet Archive, "significant cultural hubs that seemingly have the impression of lasting 'forever' have also been sites of large-scale, unrecoverable loss" (2026:18). Based on a sampling of almost a million URLs active between 2013 and 2023, the Pew Research Center reports that a quarter are no longer accessible (cited in Messarra et al. 2026). Reliance on the corporate interests behind social media sites for stable hosting results in content disappearing without warning.[18] Finding ways to support data sharing across the folk scene, especially after the Access Folk project ceases to exist in 2027, became an increasingly pressing priority as we witnessed practical challenges.

Making a plan: Institutional repositories and open research

We initially planned to deposit data generated through the SPGs in TUoS's institutional repository, ORDA.[19] Using ORDA, research support services told us, is strongly encouraged in the absence of "a subject-specific repository or data centre" (TUoS 2026b)—something we lacked. As the academic team had already used ORDA to store and share early outputs, continuing with the same platform allowed us to build on our existing knowledge and keep our data in a single location. Though intended for making non-sensitive data publicly available online, we (wrongly) hoped that ORDA's capacity to restrict and/or embargo access would enable us to navigate issues like the identifiability of our research subjects or the complex intellectual property rights inherent in our data (Draisey-Collishaw 2025). We remained keenly aware that ORDA is not a particularly intuitive or externally discoverable interface, especially for non-academics,[20] but we planned on using more user-friendly and audience-focused formats to curate the stable links (also known as DOIs—digital object identifiers) generated through the platform. It was not an ideal solution but, faced with a dearth of viable alternatives, we figured that ORDA at least offered a stable, long-term access solution.

[18] E.g., when SmugMug purchased Flickr in 2019, millions of photos were deleted from free accounts (Hern 2018). MySpace lost all music uploaded between 2003 and 2015 (Tiffany 2019) and Google deleted data from Google+ accounts when it shut down its social media platform in 2019 (Liptak 2019). For other examples, see Messarra et al. 2026.

[19] ORDA is TUoS's instance of Figshare.

[20] Institutional repositories enable researchers to meet funder demands for open data sharing. They often exist without consideration of the purpose(s) of preservation and may lack clear dissemination strategy or defined collection management plan. The broadness of their remit enables flexible adoption across wide-ranging research contexts but also limits their capacity to meet specific disciplinary priorities.

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Based on guidance from TUoS's open research and copyright teams about key regulatory challenges, our planning prioritised the FAIR Principles. We contemplated the data we anticipated collecting, how we sought to use it, and the risks associated with reuse. Based on CARE, we also considered who might benefit from access. We developed protocols—and elaborate spreadsheets—for recording critical metadata. Our consent forms flagged intentions to share data beyond the project and offered detailed explanations about what it means to be identifiable. We developed written guidelines for what our partners and their participants could share with us, highlighting preferred formats and file types. We also offered detailed descriptions of how intellectual property rights work in England and encouraged creators to apply Creative Commons licences as a means of protecting their rights and enabling reuse. After several iterations of the various forms, templates, collaboration agreements, and supporting workflows, research support services reviewed our proposed processes and deemed them adequate to our open research goals.

Practical challenges: Folk singing in England

The SPG projects focused on amateur participation in the folk scene. Labels like "singaround," "song share," "folk club," "singing session," "floor spot," or "chorus singing" are insider terms describing a variety of communal singing practices that involve people coming together, often in a pub, around the practice of singing (Wettermark 2025). Participation includes both professionals and amateurs, though status and role within the singing activity have more to do with perceived relationship to "the tradition" than professional standing. While there are clear leaders in the performance, that role may pass to others as people take turns, sometimes singing solo, sometimes in groups, and sometimes joining a soloist on choruses (MacKinnon [1993] 1994; Hield and Crossley 2014; Dunn [1980] 2015; Gordon et al. 2024).[21] Gatherings typically depend on volunteers for organisation, with those individuals determining the character of the activities they lead through (often unconscious) decision-making about everything from times and places for gathering, to the layout of spaces, flow, how participants join in (Hield 2013), behaviour moderation (Hield and Mansfield 2019), the nature of acceptable contributions (Mansfield 2026; Miller 2026), and marketing.

[21] See Curry (2026) for examples of the types of repertoire and participatory practices that are typical of the folk scene in England. One of the access challenges identified by SPG holder Sophie Crawford is that newcomers to folk singing, regardless of their experience as musicians, struggle to understand the participatory nature of events. In collaboration with Crawford and participants in the Harrison Singaround, Access Folk commissioned Fifth Column Films to create a short documentary depicting what a typical twenty-first-century singaround looks and sound like. Staging a singaround, rather than directly sharing ethnographic research data, is a workaround for openly sharing project data; it comes with labour and production costs but ensures that (1) everyone in the room has signed appropriate waivers, and (2) only repertoire that is public domain or that has full rights clearances is included. The film, along with short reels for sharing over social media platforms, is an awareness raising tool for folk organisers, and freely available for download and reuse under an open licence (CC BY-NC-ND 4.0).

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The scene is steeped in discourses about the Commons, tradition, volunteerism, and aural transmission of repertoire, often mitigating desires to understand intellectual property law as relevant. Informal participatory music scenes such as this one depend on ideas about goodwill, fair play, and shared heritage to function (MacKinnon [1993] 1994; cf. McCann 2001)—though these values may be contested when creators perceive their rights to have been violated.[22] Regular gatherings of singers, musicians, and dancers make recordings that they share, either informally on social media or through archives and commercial recording projects. Session facilitators, too, make recordings, compile songbooks, and share playlists that help participants learn repertoire. And, dancers use recordings they find on YouTube to accompany themselves in the absence of live musicians. As Jones and Cameron point out, "historically many tunes that have become part of the folk repertoire have a traceable author. Likewise, it would take a real purist not to acknowledge that much modern music has been written in a traditional style and assimilated to what many would now call folk music" (2005:260). Consent from creators to share their work is often assumed by scene membership, enabling largely informal and non-commercial practices to continue with minimal supporting infrastructure.

Though valuing shared heritage practices might discourage some practitioners from thinking too closely about intellectual property rights, understanding how relevant legal concepts apply is particularly important in the context of digital sharing, where reach and usage have unknown dimensions and consequences. One SPG holder, for example, realised there were additional personal and legal risks when they sought to translate their hardcopy songsheets into a shareable online resource. As they often did not have documentation of song sources—let alone relevant rights clearances—they were unable to assess which materials might violate copyright or licensing terms. Given the significant required labour, they opted to put that element of their project on hold until they could adequately assess the risks.

Similar challenges existed across the datasets associated with Access Folk's research, often related to ongoing efforts by both the academic team and SPG holders to square norms of the scene with the requirements of research institutions. For data to be held in institutional data repositories, full clearance of intellectual property rights is non-negotiable. For audiovisual documentation, this means identifying and gaining the explicit consent of all performers, requesting licenses from the people who created the documentation, and clearing third-party copyrights for all songs. Similar clearances are needed for ephemera associated with singing activities, like songsheets. At a minimum, this sort of rights research is labour intensive, requiring detailed record-keeping about performers and extensive archival searches to identify unknown songs, sources, and creation dates. Given the nature of

[22] E.g., The Morris Federation released a compilation CD of dance music in 2025 (Morris Federation 2025). Misunderstandings about how copyright and licensing work resulted in withdrawal of the recording, some heated social media debates, and clear upset on the part of some (not all) performers whose rights were infringed. The varied reactions of performers, volunteer producers, and observers revealed differing understandings of ownership that are not fully compatible with local regulations.

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the folk scene and song-sharing activities, not to mention gaps in available records about song sources, this type of rights research and clearance often is not possible.[23]

The informal nature of participation also poses challenges for privacy, data protection, and consent. Participants drop in and out of activities held in public or semi-public spaces. Sometimes they become session regulars but, just as often, they share a single song, coming and going before anyone can catch their name —or a song title and source. Participants, too, might be well-known professionals or local legends who are identifiable to anyone with a passing knowledge of England's folk scene, ruling out potential for anonymity. Participating might involve singing a solo, joining in imperceptibly on a rowdy mass chorus, or sitting quietly and observing. The nature of such events makes it equally difficult to identify or anonymise everyone present, let alone gain research institution-approved consents and permissions. This is especially true in a scene that depends on the labour of time-poor volunteers who may not have relevant specialised knowledge or the capacity to tackle the substantial documentation associated with provenance and rights clearances.

The participatory nature of the SPG projects added to the inherent challenges, making our open research goals particularly difficult to manage. SPG holders signed collaboration agreements with Access Folk that specified their roles in research activities, obligations for data sharing, identification in relation to their data, and withdrawal processes, but the academic team often did not have direct relationships with participants. Based on the set of templates and processes that TUoS research services approved, informed consent procedures were adapted on a case-by-case basis in consultation with SPG holders. Alterations accounted for distinctions in whether the partner was an organisation (with its own robust consent, safeguarding, and data management procedures) or an individual; the knowledge and experience of the SPG holder; the types of participants involved; the public or private nature of interventions; and the nature of risks associated with data collection activities. In a few cases, the academic team directly ran consent procedures and data collection activities, but more often the SPG partner took a leading role in assessing and administering the most appropriate procedures for their specific context.

As the academic team were rarely present during project activities, we depended on SPG holders to institute negotiated procedures and gather required documentation. This might include posting a notice about research activities, sharing a consent form, circulating a survey, or facilitating contact with a rights holder. The SPG holders' varied circumstances meant the results were uneven. Shared data, for example, sometimes lacked necessary details about provenance, consent, and licensing. It was not that SPG holders perceived these details as unimportant, but their primary concern was efficiently enabling participation on terms that suited their participants' needs. One intervention, for example,

[23] Korn et al. also point out that historically marginalised groups, like women, are less likely to be included in the existing digital record, making it much more difficult to find rights holders. This absence ends up exacerbating the underrepresentation of minoritised groups in archives and repositories when rights cannot be cleared (2026:404).

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that was situated in a multicultural urban centre, targeted young, historically marginalised, and politically active participants for informal drop-in singing sessions in an outdoor setting. Written documentation imposed a problematic level of formality on the event and was greeted with suspicion by some participants, so organisers preferred careful conversations for explaining data usage and ways of opting out.[24] The SPG holder only shared data once they were satisfied that identifiable participants were happy with its use by the Access Folk project. Though this arguably is the most ethical approach given the circumstances, the lack of documentation trail has proven tricky to manage downstream.

We sought to minimise the administrative burden associated with the research elements of projects by providing SPG holders with templates for recording key details about the data they shared—though as feedback from some SPG holders later revealed, we sometimes needed to go further to streamline research processes. We learned that even when we summarise relevant regulations and ethical considerations, our partners may not take that information on board, either due to capacity or interest. SPG holders generously shared photos and videos that they gathered from participants alongside descriptive accounts of their planning, processes, and impact. But data sometimes were shared in formats (or via platforms) that we could not accept. Some SPG holders, for example, preferred the convenience of WhatsApp to secure file uploads; unfortunately, Meta's lack of compliance with UK GDPR (2016) meant we were unable to accept data over WhatsApp. Repeatedly asking for the same data to be shared differently tested everyone's patience! Likewise, we all struggled to understand why it was okay to publicly share recordings and photos over Instagram, Facebook, or on partner websites, but that same material could not be included as research data without considerable extra labour on the part of SPG holders and their participants.

While asking our partners to document consent and licensing agreements was the right thing to do in terms of protecting people's rights (and fulfilling our institutional requirements), relations with some SPG holders soured if requests were perceived as only relevant to university systems—or, indeed, if conversations about ethics and governance were perceived as suggesting negligence on the part of research partners. But without formal documentation of consent and licensing from all rights holders, our options for processing the data remain limited. And there is the rub. At the end of this project, we will be able to produce academic papers reporting on the results of the project. The supporting datasets —the videos, photos, and creative outputs—that are most valuable to our partners may not be findable, accessible, or reusable by scene stakeholders,

[24] This preference for informal conversation to written documentation is perhaps best understood with reference to legal actions taken against protesters in the UK. From the repressive use of public order laws to quash disruptive but peaceful climate protests organised by Extinction Rebellion (Taylor and Murray 2020) to the proscription of Palestine Action under the Terrorism Act (2000) in 2025, journalists, academics, and political campaigners consistently report a chilling effect that influences decisions to "act or to speak when it would have been perfectly lawful to do so" (Mead 2026).

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given the high burden of labour required of community partners (cf. Luyk 2015:10; Post 2017; Seeger 1986).

A plan undone: The limits of our institutional repository

Despite our carefully planned consent and data intake processes, within a year it became apparent that ORDA was not fit for our purposes. Our first brush with this reality came in September 2024 when we tried to share a short field recording from a workshop run by SPG holders Sarah Hinds and Miriam McDonald (Heartwood Social Farming Centre n.d.). Seeking to improve rural access and mobilise multiple "folk song adjacent" interest groups, the duo offered workshops that explored intersections between landwork, craft, song, and folkloric knowledge at Heartwood Social Farming Centre, just outside of Matlock, Derbyshire (Draisey-Collishaw and Wettermark 2024; cf. Camlin 2024). Sharing this particular field recording via ORDA should have been straightforward: I was the recordist and the video was framed so that Hinds's image and voice were the only identifiable elements. The workshop participants had, in any case, consented to videorecording, photography, long-term archiving, and reuse—details that I discussed directly with the participants before I made the recording. Trying to share the recording showed up a first major structural barrier to using ORDA to store ethnographic data.

The field recording features Hinds using a call-and-response approach to teach a song chorus while participants harvest willow branches for use in basket weaving. The chorus is from "Willow," an original song by Rachel Newton and Sechou Keita that was released in 2019 on *The Lost Words* (Spell Songs 2019). The content of the field recording, in other words, includes third-party copyrights that require clearance before sharing via ORDA. In this case, identifying the songwriters was easy, though finding out who owns the publishing rights has proven complicated—as of February 2026, we still do not have a license to share the recording. But we also questioned whether we *needed* a license. Given the content and quality of the recording, did our usage constitute "fair dealing"? Rather than high-quality audiovisual documentation of a performance and song, this lo-fi field recording—made "for our own research purposes"—features a single line of the song chorus sung repetitively. The recording focuses on the means and context for participant engagement, illustrating details outlined in reporting by SPG holders, testimonials by participants, and my own fieldnotes about how the functional approach to singing supports access for different populations. The song and performance are incidental and the recording is unlikely to affect the market value of the original work.

This example exemplifies the nature of multimodal ethnomusicological data: the recording is only meaningful data when combined with other documentation. While the data infrastructure for ORDA is well-suited to preserve and share multimodal digital data, the risk-intolerant nature of the repository means that content under copyright—even when there is an applicable fair dealing exception—cannot be stored or shared. As Wakaruk et al. explain, "Anyone who works with copyright in higher education knows that the interpretation of related legal provisions is often case-specific and does not lend itself to bright-line legal tests.

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Fair dealing is also similarly constructed," often leading to overly conservative assessments of what is possible in the existing regulatory context (2025:12–13). When ambiguities exist about songs or rights holders, the assumption must be that content is still under copyright or usage is unconsented, as institutional repositories are risk intolerant. Indeed, as Wakaruk et al. (2025) reveal, growing rates of "copyright anxiety" in the higher education sector result in changes to research, publication, and teaching outcomes that avoid potential risks associated with copyrighted materials, even where a risk-managed approach might be more appropriate (cf. The National Archives 2021).

While we interpreted copyright infringement risks associated with our field recording as low, we were also pragmatic about our chances of swaying ORDA's intake policies. We started looking for workarounds. We queried, for example, whether licensing from the Performing Rights Society for Music[25] might work as a strategy for ensuring copyright compliance and royalty payment to relevant rights holders (PRS 2025). As researchers, however, we were unable to purchase a streaming licence for our collection. PRS's suggestion that the repository might opt to licence their entire platform likewise proved impractical, running to a cost of thousands of pounds per year. Even our research team had to concede that this was an unsustainable expense, especially given that (1) we were among the only current users seeking a streaming licence, (2) the small number of streams we expected, and (3) the overall low risk associated with the content.

The challenge of depositing our data to ORDA also involved privacy and data protection considerations. Another SPG holder, Rupert Philbrick of Music at the Heart of Teesdale, shared audiovisual documentation of a Wassail event with Access Folk, alongside written reflections and interviews about introducing singing into the activities of an existing youth folk band (ages 11–17).[26] The recording features Philbrick leading a group of interested young musicians in singing "The Wassail Song" at a community event in Weardale, Co. Durham. Again, sharing this recording seemed straightforward: "The Wassail Song" is in the public domain; Music at the Heart of Teesdale applied a Creative Commons license to the recording itself; and, because the Wassail event was the focus of a short documentary being made by an external funder (see Weardale Together 2025), all participants signed recording releases. The recording in question is an outtake that provides high-quality documentation of Philbrick's work with young folk musicians. While we hold correspondence from Music at the Heart of Teesdale explaining that all persons identifiable in the recording have consented, we do not directly hold documentation of their consent. This introduces questions about data provenance and whether we have the right to deposit the recording as part of our dataset. Though the documentation relates to Access Folk's research, it was generated by a non-academic partner. As Philbrick does not have a university affiliation, he cannot directly deposit the recording in ORDA. Philbrick, as well, is conscious of the youthful nature of the participants;

[25] The organisation that licenses usage and distributes royalties for all registered musical works and musicians in the UK.

[26] Wassail is a winter folk tradition in England that involves blessing orchards for a good harvest in the coming season.

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while happy for the recording to be part of the project dataset—accessible and reusable for future research—he does not want the recording to be freely downloadable online. His terms of sharing demanded controlled access—a specification that ORDA simply cannot answer (Research Data Services, email to author, 29 May 2025).

Investigating alternatives and weighing priorities

In early summer 2025, we turned to the UK Data Service—the UK's largest digital repository for social science and humanities research—as a solution for our data sharing challenges. Like ORDA in terms of function, this specialist service offers controlled access to data collections, a characteristic that we hoped would enable a risk-managed approach to the rights and provenance issues inherent in our data. Depositing to this service, however, requires institutional affiliation. Even more problematically given our prioritisation of data sharing with stakeholders in the folk scene, institutional affiliation is also required to use controlled access collections. In the end, asking "open for whom" proved unnecessary. The risks around consent and anonymity inherent in our data, the UK Data Service assessed, would require their SecureLab, a service that "provides controlled access to data that are too detailed, sensitive or confidential to be made available under the standard End User Licence or Special License" (UK Data Service 2026b). Unfortunately, this service is only available for use with quantitative datasets, which ruled us out.

Our discussions with the UK Data Service made one thing very clear: though most of our data take the form of interview transcriptions, written reflections, and fieldnotes, even minimal inclusion of audiovisual formats with complex rights all but requires involvement of a sound archive. More specifically, we needed specialist knowledge of relevant regulatory issues, as well as the capacity to take a more risk-managed approach to our dataset. In late autumn 2025, we turned to the British Library Sound Archive: to our knowledge, the only sound archive available to us in England with a national remit suitable to the scope of our project.

In theory, depositing our data with the British Library was an ideal solution: they handle multimedia data, provide controlled access, take a risk-managed approach to rights management, and, importantly, they are accessible to the public—our stakeholders would be able to access the data. The complicating factor was a cyberattack that targeted The British Library in October 2023. The attack crippled the organisation and, more than two years later, leaves the organisation working at reduced capacity (Ash 2024; Keating 2024; Stavrou 2025). In this context, curators are reluctant to accession data from external researchers. Beyond capacity and regardless of their ability to manage multimedia data, one curator informed me that the structure of the institution may not be suitable for the preservation and dissemination of multimodal datasets. The curators at the British Library approach data intake by modality; individual curators are responsible for different types of data (e.g., audiovisual recordings, photos, and scores). Each curator evaluates data items separately according to their section's collection priorities. Different curators, for example, would assess

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the lo-fi field recording of Sarah Hinds teaching "Willow" and the accompanying documentation that gives the data meaning. While there is potential to link accessioned data and liaise with relevant curators, it is unlikely that our multimodal dataset would be accepted in its entirety. Initial conversations suggest that depositing our data with the British Library will not be simple given the institution's current reduced capacity, the complexity of our dataset, and the time limits imposed by the end of Access Folk's funding.

It is now January 2026, and I have been working on Access Folk's open research strategy for more than two years. I have not been alone on this journey. I am part of an incredible team of researchers, each offering specialised and complementary knowledge relevant to achieving our research goals. Yet even with the luxury of a well-resourced project and a dedicated multi-person team working in concert with the stated priorities of our institution and funder—and with support from key stakeholders within the folk scene—realising the full extent of our open research objectives remains elusive. Our participatory methods, prioritisation of co-produced research and outputs, and publication of results in open non/academic formats mean we have done a good job on the "science communication, open engagement of societal actors and open dialogue with other knowledge systems" elements of UNESCO's open research definition (2021). Indeed, after the Access Folk project wraps up at the end of January 2027, our open access outputs will continue to be stably shared on ORDA for anyone with the interest and know-how to locate an institutional repository. But though we'll have a well-documented dataset that is mostly compliant with the FAIR Principles, that data will nevertheless remain largely inaccessible to stakeholders interested in building on our work.

Open research in ethnomusicology

The challenges I've outlined in this article are complexly entangled and play out in highly localised ways. Finding solutions cannot depend on lone ethnomusicologists engineering bespoke workarounds to their data management needs—or, indeed, ignoring core challenges by locking data away in personal archives. Nor can we depend on institutional research support teams or external repositories and archives to engineer solutions to challenges that they are ill-positioned to fully comprehend. Their interests and priorities, moreover, may at times exist in tension with those of music scholars. Structured with anonymous quantitative datasets in mind, institutional repositories, for example, support academic publishing and enable researchers to meet funder requirements for open datasets. They are often ill-suited to host ethnographic data that include in/direct identifiers and complex intellectual property rights, or to accession co-produced data that require interfacing beyond researcher communities. Given the costs and complexities, there is little motivation to proactively address key challenges for music scholars. Archives, on the other hand, tend to prioritise potential for dissemination and community engagement. Capacity and resource limits, however, mean that they are often reluctant to preserve data with limited potential for reuse because of problems with provenance or regulatory restrictions.

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Finding solutions that meet the needs of ethnomusicological research, I would like to suggest, requires four concerted disciplinary-level actions:

1. **Defining ethnomusicological data** in terms of recognised data governance principles (e.g., FAIR, CARE, or other) so that we can more effectively articulate our data management needs to relevant non-ethnomusicologist stakeholders. This includes identifying the limits of extant systems when it comes to methodological priorities and disciplinary norms, ethical considerations, data ownership, approaches to risk management, regulatory compliance, and infrastructure. Arriving at a definition of ethnomusicological data that is useful beyond individual circumstance will require the input and expertise of ethnomusicologists working in a variety of inter/national contexts and to vastly varying ends.
2. **Multidisciplinary collaborations on systematic approaches to data management** that have potential for application beyond individual projects and research contexts. Bringing together ethnomusicologists with data management professionals, systems engineers, and legal scholars offers potential for exploring solutions, like how the structures of open data repositories might more effectively interface with traditional brick-and-mortar archives or how smart contracts might use Creative Commons Licences and Traditional Knowledge labels to track provenance, enable access, and protect rights holders. The possibilities for creative solutions are vast if we bring a clear definition of our data management needs (and those of the communities we work with) into dialogue with the ingenuity of multidisciplinary teams.
3. **Replicating data management solutions** in wide-ranging inter/national contexts. Testing approaches to data management that are intended for more systematic application in a variety of research, regulatory, and cultural contexts offers potential for understanding how systems can be localised without requiring reinvention. Developing standardised workflows, systems, and infrastructure offers greater potential for supporting sustainable access to the knowledge that our partners and participants share.
4. **Education on data management**, especially how principles of data governance might more consistently be integrated into research design. This recommendation might involve creating training materials based on solutions proposed through multidisciplinary collaborations or leveraging existing publication structures to broaden awareness (and incentivise) engagement with existing approaches to data sharing.

The challenges of open research are unlikely to go away anytime soon. While open research involves more than data sharing, robust data governance procedures are nevertheless necessary for sustainable openness. Discussing the data governance principles that support open research highlights how disciplinary-level neglect of data management fails our interlocutors and limits potential for systems reform. We need tough conversations about who owns and has the right to access knowledge (not just ethically, but also in legal

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terms), how preservation perpetuates or resists colonisation, how technology might help us negotiate more equitable research relationships, and the data governance commonalities that cross our research sites. We need, in short, to look beyond the risks and unique qualities that distinguish each research site so that we can bring the incredible knowledge that exists between us to bear on new regulatory, technical, and data governance challenges.

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